



YOUR KINDLE NOTES FOR:

Amped (Vintage Contemporaries)

by Daniel H. Wilson

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36 Highlights | 1 Note

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 1

In the first months of use, your Neural Autofocus MK-4® Brain Implant will develop an accurate model of your brain function. In response to the unit, your own neural circuits will adapt, strengthening existing pathways associated with concentration and motor function. This feedback process will continue throughout the lifetime of the implant device. Please note that these changes are irreversible, even if use of the implant is discontinued.

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The question in this case is whether users of implantable technology (e.g., Neural Autofocus® units) are guaranteed a right to education under the Fourteenth Amendment.

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The case of *Brown v. Board of Education*, 347 U.S. 483, established that public institutions may not discriminate against students based on their immutable characteristics. We hold that the use of implantable technology constitutes an elective surgery, and that there is therefore no protection for implanted citizens under the Fourteenth Amendment. Therefore, we hold that implanted citizens are not a protected class. It is so ordered.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 8

that's how it started. With sweet little Sam walking back into my classroom, looking me right in the eye with a new spark of intelligence—a new electricity altogether. Where'd the spark come from? It's simple enough. An aspirin-sized piece of conductive metal, an amp, carefully placed in the prefrontal cortex of the kid's brain. A baby squid pulsing with an exquisitely timed series of electrical stimulations, gently pushing her mind toward the beta one wave state. Focused concentration, 24-7. This sharpened focus massively amplified her intelligence, bulldozing away the dim, mild, slobber-mouthed little girl I knew. And only a little nub of dark plastic on her temple, like a mole, to show for it. A maintenance port. Just like mine.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 9

Still, turning my implant off is not an option. And that's the bitch of it. These tools we love so much have burrowed under our skin like parasites. They're in our brains now, our joints and organs. Crouching behind our eyeballs and clinging to our sinuses. Making us smarter and stronger and always, always more dependent.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 14

storey

Edit

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he doesn't promote hate but calls the struggle between amps and "pure humans" a war. Never condones violence but supports self-defense for any person whose way of life is under attack. Claims only to target extremist amps, but says that among amps, well, extremism is mainstream.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 23

The letterhead is marked with an official seal: a coat of arms with the words "Pure Human Citizen's Council" on a circular banner, wrapped around the bas-relief image of a smiling little girl with a clean temple. Beneath her face, the word "Elysium" is embossed. Faintly, I notice the first and last letters of the word are bigger. Somehow familiar. I've seen those two letters before, in a tattoo: EM.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 36

It's the Joseph Vaughns of the world who have given regular people license to act like this. Talking heads on television who have repeated the incendiary words again and again until the insane has become commonplace. This guy sitting here wearing his work clothes isn't a monster, he probably has a wife and kids and— "Hey!" he shouts. The cashier walks over, shoes squeaking on tile. Puts a hand on my shoulder. "We don't want trouble. You got to go," he says quietly. "I'll go when I'm ready," I say. "Let's see your temple, buddy," calls the painter again. I

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 66

Lot of test subjects out there with all kinds of crazy junk in their heads." Is that what we are? A nation of test subjects? Involuntary participants in a never-ending social experiment, exposed to wave after wave of new technology? Nick points along a row of run-down trailers. "Over there's my house. Earl. Miranda. Jim." The kid stops at a dark trailer on the end. It has an ominous red star spray-painted on its side, paint bleeding from it in dried rivulets. "Lyle and them guys are in those boxes there." The laughing cowboy and his gang. I try to act casual.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 73

Eden may feel calm right this instant, but tension crackles just beneath every movement. Every sound. It's a fragile picture of normalcy, wavering in the reflection of a soap bubble.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 85

Nick picked up on my schedule pretty quick. Lately, I've found him waiting, crouched inside the rotten old hot tub sitting on Jim's porch. I can hear his giggles from the porch steps. Every day, he jumps out to surprise me—a demented jack-in-the-box. And every day, I go ahead and act surprised.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 101

“Gotta understand the machine's a part of you. Lose the amp, you lose your mind. Brain is the sum of its parts. Hindbrain's got your instinct for survival. Limbic is where love and hate live. Neocortex has got your imagination in it. And your amp is another part. What it does is up to you.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 103

“There's one thing that regulars know deep down and it scares the shit out of 'em. Being an amp don't make you any less human, brother. Being an amp makes you more human.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 147

It's time to see what I'm capable of. Three. Two. One. Zero. And the amp speaks to me. It's a startling, synthesized voice in my head: Level one. Diagnostic access. Battlefield situational awareness. Mission essential fitness. Mobility and survivability. Do you consent? Do you consent?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 153

I climb the wooden ladder tipped against the end of the trailer. Jim is barefoot and bare chested up here, wearing his exoskeleton. The old man slowly lunges through the motions of one of his tai chi routines. His skin gleams in the light from antique sodium arc lamps. I watch him practice the martial art for a few seconds, somehow soothed by each deliberate movement, every slow-motion strike and block executed with centimeter-level precision. Whatever form he is doing, I imagine that with the help of the exoskeleton he's executing it more perfectly than any ancient master ever did.

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“Mind and body,” he says. “You know what you get when the mind and body act as one?” he asks. Jim resumes moving, sinking toward me. His hands scoop the air, rise with animal grace. “You get harmony,” he answers. “Remember that. There is no you. There is no it. Mind and body need a single purpose.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 157

Something big moves, like a skyscraper swaying in the wind. It's the Brain. Sitting on a tree stump, he's got a forty in one hand. Makes the beer look the size of a sippy cup.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 159

“Ad astra cruentus,” says Lyle, and the people around the campfire mutter in unison: “To the stars. Stained in blood.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 159

Pushing my focus to the Zenith, on the verge of the trigger, tickles something. Like pressing a hidden button. Three, two, one, zero. Fist. It’s as though I’ve fallen through a trapdoor and into my own brain. Thoughts are written on the inside of my forehead. I can see them scrolling there. White text on black background. Speeding past at the speed of thought. Level two. Close-quarter combatives. Fluid shock striking technique. Vital points. Nerve motor points. Defensive stances. Do you consent? Do you consent?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 164

“You ever hear of the scala naturae?” “Aristotle. The great chain of being. A medieval categorization of living things. Before there was a difference between science and religion.” Lyle shakes his head at me, lips curling up at the corners, takes a drag. “Teacher,” I say, shrugging. “Then you know the order,” says Lyle. “Plants, animals, men, angels, then God. Difference between men and angels is that men are stuck in a body. They feel pain, hunger, thirst. But me and you, we don’t have to feel them things. Body diagnostics come on level one. Easy. We can turn off the human condition. So maybe we’re closer to angels, you know? Creatures of the mind. A higher morality.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 167

“You’ll see better in the dark. Hear better than a field mouse. All that shit. But the real advantage is in the connections. Zenith will use the extra information. Retinal talks. Cochlear talks. Zenith takes you to another level. Full sensory network.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 172

My mind and body are still out of tune. I hope they run into each other real soon. —JIM MORRISON

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Level three. Tactical maneuvers. Evasion. Room clearing. Flanking. Improvised weaponry. Combat medicine. Do you consent? Do you consent? Yes, oh fuck, yes, yes.

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Level four. Man-portable weapon systems. Small arms. Infantry support. Lethal organic fire support. Obstacle

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Level five. Full sensory networking. Long horizon mission planning. Command and control. Enhanced mobility and survivability. Do you consent? Do you consent? Begging me to go whole hog. Real power is in the connections between things, Lyle said. The pieces are in place but it's up to me to turn them on. Give the go-ahead to let the retinal talk to the neural. Cochlear talk to retinal. The world opens up to you in ways you can't imagine.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 237

One arm hooked over a trash can, Perry roots for stale bread and continues his monologue. "Lucky, we are. Yes, sir. Lucky to live in this cutting-edge era of progress. When men can aspire not only to be well and healthy, but to be better than well. Better than healthy. If you ponder it, Owen, why, it's clear that you and me are technological marvels of the modern age!"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 245

I take a deep breath and do what Lyle taught me to do. Focus on my goal up front.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 249

"I used the Zenith. All of it." Lucy puts a hand over her mouth. Nick leans forward, eyes bright. "What's it like?" he asks. "Like ... being a ghost. Watching somebody else's life. Seeing events unfold precisely according to a plan that nobody told you." "Like destiny," muses Nick. Destiny. I think about how it feels to fall down inside my own head. The potential outcomes of my actions laid out in colored stripes on the ground. Dance steps painted in invisible ink. Could I choose to do something else? I realize I haven't tried.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 255

Is this really you, Owen? Am I a killer? I don't know. It occurs to me that my body operates almost entirely without listening to my opinion—balancing, daydreaming, and healing itself, not to mention breathing and digesting food and a million other little things. I'm not sure how much control I really have anymore. How much control did I ever have?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 267

I gave you something extra, Owen. Level six. Freedom from suffering. Full executive extinguished. A conduit to your soul. Thought to action. I love you, son. I trust you. Do good. Do you consent? Do you consent? He left this message for me. All this time. My father. Do you consent? I consider it for a fragment of a second. Yes. The Zenith awakes.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 272

We're all of us on islands. That's what Nick says. According to the chattering kid, everybody, whether they're an amp or a reggie, is on one kind of island or another. Millions of islands, millions of sharks. But billions of

bridges. It's the connections between the things that are important, he says. More important than the things themselves. Nick has a new backpack and that same old faded Rubik's cube.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 273

I open the door for Nick and his friends. Follow them in. Inside, thirty-five pairs of eyes stare up at me. Thirty-five nodules on temples, some decorated with glitter and neon lights and others just left alone. The kids sit on government-supplied folding chairs around three mismatched tables. There are no recognizable grade levels. The difficulty of the material has to do with your implant and your natural intelligence. Age is immaterial for these amps.

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"Okay, class," I say. "Today, we're going to study government. There aren't enough books, so those of you with modded retinal implants should scan the pages and then share with your neighbor." Humankind needs technology. It's the one thing that we do better than any other animal. We communicate, cooperate, and make tools to extend our reach. Every new tool changes us. As we grow, sometimes parents find they can't recognize their children. The old fears the new, and the two threaten to destroy each other. Our technology is what makes us strong. And it's what makes us dangerous.

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I've heard it said that technology makes a good person better, and it makes a bad person worse.

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we keep building new versions of ourselves, keep exploring the unknown, and keep growing. We're gonna be fine. Different, but fine. Because most people are good. Right?
